chains. Authority belongs to the people who control the junctions that link the various chains. These junctions are the tribe's foundational myths. Charismatic leaders, orators and mythmakers know how to use these stories in order to shape identities, build alliances and sway emotions.[34]

In human networks connected by written documents and bureaucratic procedures – from ancient Ur to modern India – society relies in part on the interaction between humans and documents. In addition to human-to-human and human-to-story chains, such societies are held together by human-to-document chains. When we observe a bureaucratic society at work, we still see humans telling stories to other humans, as when millions of Indians watch the *Ramayana* series, but we also see humans passing documents to other humans, as when TV networks are required to apply for broadcasting licences and fill out tax reports. Looked at from a different perspective, what we see is documents compelling humans to engage with other documents.

This led to shifts in authority. As documents became a crucial nexus linking many social chains, considerable power came to be invested in these documents, and experts in the arcane logic of documents emerged as new authority figures. Administrators, accountants and lawyers mastered not just reading and writing but also the skills of composing forms, separating drawers and managing archives. In bureaucratic systems, power often comes from understanding how to manipulate obscure budgetary loopholes and from knowing your way around the labyrinths of offices, committees and subcommittees.

This shift in authority changed the balance of power in the world. For better or worse, literate bureaucracies tended to strengthen the central authority at the expense of ordinary citizens. It's not just that documents and archives made it easier for the centre to tax, judge and conscript everybody. The difficulty of understanding bureaucratic power simultaneously made it harder for the masses to influence, resist or evade the central authority. Even when bureaucracy was a benign force, providing people with sewage systems, education and security, it still tended to increase the gap between rulers and ruled. The system enabled the centre to collect and record a lot more information about the people it governed, while the latter found it much more difficult to understand how the system itself worked.